

Light computing

Photonic Computing which will be based on the transfer of photons instead of electrons, is bound to increase the speed of computing to unimaginable levels

Future interface

SixthSense developed by MIT's Pranav Mistry is a wearable gestural interface that will let us interact with information using natural hand gestures



The second lap

Sriram Sharma

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

Forget 2012, and the singularity. We're going to try and envision the future of personal computers and technology beyond 2015.

To start off with this feature on future predictions, which will only deal with certainties, we would like to assure our readers that world is not ending in 2012. NASA, in fact had a news release dismissing claims about a phantom planet or galactic alignment that could bring the end of the world. "Even if these alignments were to occur, their effects on the Earth would be negligible", says a news release. "Each December the Earth and sun align with the approximate centre of the Milky Way Galaxy, but that is an annual event of no consequence."

However, it is difficult to gaze into a crystal ball, and project a grandiose vision of future technologies. Five-year plans are best left to socialist govern-

ments. However, given that we live in India, and only got 3G close to a decade after Japan got it, it should be fairly easy to predict the future of technology in India, by looking at what is happening around the world.

The future is the past

This is an industry where intellectual property, software and interface patents, and walled gardens help retain precarious monopolies. It's hard not to be cynical, when you realise that we're yet to see a \$100 laptop or a Rs. 10,000 Android. Our bandwidth is capped at 10 GB, while countries like Finland have declared bandwidth a birthright.

Basically, the future of computing in India is the past in many developed countries.

Tablets and touch devices

Francis Ford Coppola's movie, *Tucker: The Man and his Dream* tells the tragic story of a man who tried to take on the big auto companies in the US in the 1940s, but failed spectacularly. In mid-

2008, Michael Arrington wondered aloud why there wasn't a \$200 "Macbook Air-thin touch screen machine that runs Firefox and possibly Skype on top of a Linux kernel. It doesn't exist today, and as far as we can tell no one is creating one." Arrington later outlined his manifesto and philosophy behind the \$200 CrunchPad. The design, specifications and software would be open source, allowing anyone to build one. The last prototype, sporting a 12-inch capacitive touchscreen could run Chrome OS and Windows 7, and was expected to be launched early 2010.

Sadly, in December, Arrington declared the project dead, spilling out the gory details of "greed, jealousy and miscommunication" on TechCrunch.com, which has over three million followers on its RSS feed. He filed a lawsuit a fortnight later. The CrunchPad is now reincarnated as JooJoo, and is available for pre-order in the US for \$499 from Fusion Garage. Hopefully, he will not give up, and follow his vision through to give us a \$200 tablet by 2015.